Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Garrison Keillor's "The Anthem"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of the parody that is Keillor's treatment of the Robert Frost canon include

allusion,	internal rhyme,	persona,
anaphora,	inversion,	personification,
anastrophe (hyperbaton),	long measure,	pun,
burlesque,	macaronic rhyme,	regionalism,
diction,	meter,	resolution,
enjambment,	mood,	run-on line,
heteromerous (mosaic) rhyme,	occasional verse,	stanza,
iambic tetrameter,	parody,	syntax, and
imagery,	pathetic fallacy,	tone.

The contestant might recall encountering Keillor's poem on the regional test (which does not constitute, at least in this instance, regionalism).

The writer might begin his or her discussion by pointing out that because Robert Frost's style is, in a sense, emulated, not ridiculed, the poem is not a burlesque (or a travesty)—and while the subject of the poem is, in a careful, light manner, lowered, it is not ridiculed.

Several aspects of the poem's form suggest something of a tribute to Frost's characteristic homage-without-obsequiousness to traditional prosody: the long measure's rhyme scheme is altered; the rhymes are playful (line 6's heteromerous rhyming with line 5, as well as line 9's macaronic, arguably, and heteromerous rhyming with "doesn't care"). Something might be made of Keillor's having choosen a four-line stanza over the five-line stanza of the Frost original, a choice that lightens the tone and, perhaps, reflects a bowing to the master in the manner that Virgil wrote his epic in twelve books not twenty-four, as had his own master, Homer.

The final stanza offers the writer the best point of departure, the connection with Frost's beloved "The Road Not Taken" being painfully obvious. The writer might deduce in the certitude of the persona's declaration "But I have things to do today" a contrast to Frost's ironic "I shall be telling this with a sigh / [. . .] / I took the one less traveled by [. . .]." That both recountings suggest "And that has made all the difference" (echoed in line 15's "all is now okay") contributes to parody's success.

Additionally, the writer might note that the play on the word *hay* might serve to balance—if not distract from—the pathetic fallacy that is the horse's (and, apparently, the persona's) turning his back, quite literally, on the significance of the event to which the original anthem and this parody are directed. Notwithstanding the characterization of patriotic revolution as pandemonium (a not-so-subtle allusion to Milton's Pandæmonium), the persona's distancing himself, with his horse, from the "tumult of the sky" suggests that things are, indeed, okay enough for both of them to rest contentedly on the farm, a setting that is immediately associated with Frost's regionalism.